Aadhaar, the 12-Digit Revolution

For six decades, governments created programmes. Poverty persisted and the schemes expanded. Rajiv Gandhi famously said out of every rupee meant for welfare, "only 15 paise reached the people". The poor had no instrument to claim their rights. The idea of identity cards yo-yoed from regime to regime. In 2009, the UPA government inducted Nandan Nilekani to set up the Unique Identification Authority of India with an initial corpus of Rs 120 crore. Pranab Mukherjee provided political cover and Nilekani and then TRAI chairman R.S. Sharma powered the idea of biometric identity to create a platform for targeted delivery. The project faced public and political trial, and judicial scrutiny by the Supreme Court. BJP leaders called it a threat to the nation. Narendra Modi the candidate raised questions in the run-up to the 2014 polls. Prime Minister Modi, persuaded of its efficacy by Nilekani, adapted and adopted it. Legislative legitimacy followed, and the PM propelled its expansion. In 2022, over 1.3 billion people are enrolled. Aadhaar has enabled financial inclusion, easier access to welfare and private services and is lauded globally.



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Goods and Services Tax

For years, India endured a regime of multi-layered taxation that impacted cost of living and business competitiveness—the current fuel taxation system symbolises the ills. The concept of a unified tax system—encompassing central, state and local levies—was visualised during the A.B. Vajpayee regime. Vijay Kelkar articulated it best in his 2004 report of the Task Force on Implementation of the FRBM Act as a 'grand bargain' to foster a 'national common market'. Announcements followed—by P. Chidambaram in 2006 and Pranab Mukherjee in 2011—but debates over calibration of rates and loss compensation to states haunted formulation. Eventually, Prime Minister Narendra Modi deployed political capital to negotiate a deal and operationalise a 'one nation, one tax' regime in 2017. In five years, the GST platform, initially marred by glitches, has evolved to deliver an average Rs 1.4 lakh crore a month. Critically, it has brought sanity to the tax system. Opening up GST data can inform and improve design of policy.

E-Payments

Few could have imagined its impact when the National Payments Corporation of India was set up in 2008. A 'not for profit' government initiative funded by banks, it has designed and furnished a parade of platforms—among them, a nationwide connected ATM network, IMPS for real-time transfers, RuPay cards and the Unified Payments Interface (UPI)—in under a decade. The ubiquitous scan and pay culture, with over 7 billion transactions in a month just on UPI, symbolises the expansion and adoption of digital payments. As Prime Minister Narendra Modi observed recently, digitalisation has enabled 'democratisation of technology' in the war against poverty. India today boasts a digital payments ecosystem that is the envy of the world.



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